adrian zhang

# meltdown I

for medium ensemble

(2024)

# instrumentation:

flute
bass clarinet in Bb
large gong (doubling bass drum)
vibraphone
piano
violin
viola
cello

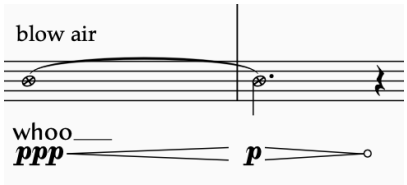
Each player plays one instrument, except for the percussionist who plays the large gong — he or she will also play the bass drum.

# performance notes:
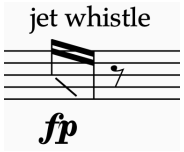
*for all instruments:*
ord. = ordinary playing

*for flute and bass clarinet:*
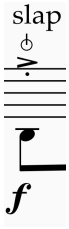
flz. = flatterzunge/flutter-tongue
A diamond notehead indicates that the notated pitch should be played airily. An “X” notehead, circled or not, indicates that the player should blow air for the duration of the note — this is usually accompanied by vowels or words providing the recommended mouth shape in order to achieve a specific timbre (shown below).




A headless notehead with a line connecting itself to another headless notehead indicates that a jet whistle should be played. The duration of the jet whistle is indicated by the duration of the first note, not the duration of both notes (shown below).




A snap symbol above a note (usually accompanied by an accent and a staccato articulation) indicates a tongue slap/ram (shown below).

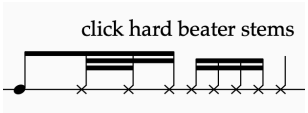



*for percussion instruments:*

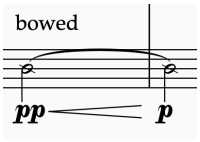
All instruments’ passages are to be played with ambience in mind, and thus all notes should be allowed to vibrate until the natural or intentional diminishing of such vibration.

*for large gong and bass drum:*

By default, both instruments are played using large, soft felt mallets.
"X" notehead notes signify the playing using the stems of both mallets, with no contact made with the instruments themselves, as shown below.




*for vibraphone:*
By default, the vibraphone is played with a small and firm rubber mallet.
Notes that have a slashed notehead indicate utilizing a cello bow to play the notated note, shown below.




*for violin, viola, and cello:*
All bowing techniques are indicated in the score with words.
Harmonics are notated in three ways; there are two notations for natural harmonics (which are the single diamond notehead with open string number, and the circle above sounding pitch) and one for artificial harmonics (which is a diamond notehead above regular notehead; regular notehead is written 2 octaves below sounding pitch).
Col legno is used in two different ways: battuto and legno. It is indicated in the score with words to differentiate between the two.

# program note:

The word “meltdown” has multiple unique meanings in different contexts. This piece explores one such meaning — that of an environmental meltdown. Whether one takes this definition literally or figuratively, this is a situation where an environment “melts down” due to its destroyed ecosystems caused by none other than us.

Images of an arctic scene slowly, then explosively progress into crashing icebergs and the cutting of trees as the piece progresses. Mixed feelings ranging from ambient neutrality and gentle content to mild discomfort and spiraling confusion are all evoked, but never truly pinpointed, symbolizing humanity’s dangerously comforting dilemma – “if it’s so harmful, why doesn’t it feel like so?” – a common mechanism employed by people who oftentimes will eventually “melt down”.

Score in C

# meltdown I

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♩=60
**flowing**

Flute
blow air
ee
p
ü uu
ppp
uu_t
< p
tü
pp
airy pitch
p
blow air
ppp

Bass Clarinet in B♭
blow air
airy pitch
whoo
ppp
p
whoo
ppp
p
ppp

Percussion
Large Gong
soft mallet
To B. D.
Bass Drum
soft felt mallet
5
l.v.
pp
To Gong
Large Gong
soft felt mallet
3
ppp

Vibraphone
always let vibrate
ppp
ppp
ppp

Piano
when
gong fully
dissipates
p
3
5
3

Violin
♩=60
**flowing**
I
pp
mp pp
IV II III
II II
pp
ppp
p

Viola
sul ponticello
III
pp
col. tratt.
III
I
p
ppp
S.T.
fp
ord.
IV
ppp
p
III II III
II
I
pizz.
p
mp

Violoncello
sul ponticello
III I II I
pp
mp
II I
pp
col. tratt.
sul tasto
ppp
ord.
3
p
col. tratt.
IV sul pont.
ppp

7
A **developing**

Fl.
airy pitch
pp p
mp
p
3
mp p
ord.
mp

B. Cl.
blow air
p
shü
fp
shü
fp
shü
fp
shü
fp
shü
fp
shü
fp
p
pp

Perc.
l.v.
p
l.v.
l.v.

Vib.
bowed
pp
p
bowed
pp

Pno.
p

sul ponticello
IV II II
A **developing**
pp
col legno battuto
p
mp
p
mp p
mp

Vln.

Vla.
col legno battuto
p
IV
sul pont.

Vc.
p
mp

13

Fl.

B. Cl.

Perc.

Vib.

Pno.

Vln.

Vla.

Vc.

ord.

ord.
arco

col legno battuto

18

simile

ord.
s.p.

col legno batt.

ord.
arco
s.p.

21

Fl.

B. Cl.

airy pitch

Perc.

Vib.

Pno.

Vln.

col legno tratto

arco ord.

Vla.

Vc.

25

Fl.

B. Cl.

To B. D.

soft felt mallet

Bass Drum

l.v.

Perc.

Vib.

Pno.

Vln.

Vla.

Vc.

29

B

Fl.

B. Cl.

ord.

blow air

whoo

with brush

Perc.

with brush

Vib.

8va

Pno.

B

Vln.

Vla.

Vc.

33

C naturally

Fl.

normal pitch

flz.

ord. vibrato

blow air

sh!

whoo

B. Cl.

Perc.

Vib.

(8)

Pno.

C naturally

Vln.

pizz.

s.p. arco

Vla.

ord. pizz.

arco s.p.

Vc.

40

Fl.

B. Cl.

Perc.

Vib.

Pno.

Vln.

Vla.

Vc.

blow air

whoo

ord.

D like an interruption

jet whistle

jet whistle

slap tongue

ord.

slap

ord.

slap

ord.

soft felt mallet

Large Gong

To Gong

click hard beater stems

click hard beater stems

motor off

bowed

use palm

D like an interruption

46

jet whistle

slap

ord.

slap

slap

ord.

Bass Drum

soft felt mallet

To B.D.

palm

palm

palm

8va

III

48

Fl.

B. Cl.

slap

ord.

slap

Perc.

To Gong

Vib.

ord.

Pno.

Vln.

Vla.

stay arco!

Vc.

III

III

III

51

E

blooming

Fl.

B. Cl.

Perc.

Vib.

Pno.

E

blooming

Vln.

sul pont.

Vla.

simile.

Vc.

III

III

III

III

56

Fl.

B. Cl.

normal pitch

Perc.

Vib.

ord.

Pno.

Vln.

Vla.

Vc.

61

F

**almost like an interruption**

jet whistle

slap tongue

click hard beater stems

use palm

64

Fl.

B. Cl.

slap
ord.

Perc.

Vib.

bowed
motor off

Pno.

palm

simile

Vln.

Vla.

slap tongue

Vc.

67

jet whistle

8va

III

69

G

**like the felling of a tree**

Fl.

B. Cl.

Perc.

To Bass Drum

Bass Drum

Vib.

Pno.

8va

Vln.

Vla.

Vc.

III

S.P.

72

flz.

airy

c.l. tratto

IV

ord.

sul pont.